



Landscape >> Parks and Gardens >>

Shaheed Ashok Kamthe Garden

Pimpri Chinchwad, India

Use – Public Garden

Size M2/Ft2 – 2600 / 27,986

Status - Completed

Reclaiming Public Space Along the Riverfront



Cities today are defined not only by their buildings and infrastructure, but by the quality of their public spaces. As urbanization accelerates across India, the pressure on cities extends beyond housing and mobility toward an equally critical question — how do we create environments that foster collective life, cultural identity and emotional well-being?

Public spaces become essential in answering this question. They are the breathing voids within dense urban fabrics — spaces where cities slow down, where communities gather, and where relationships between people and place are continuously redefined.

Located at the edge of Pune and Pimpri-Chinchwad, Garvgaatha Urban Park emerges from this larger urban condition. Conceived as a civic landscape within a rapidly transforming metropolitan corridor, the project seeks to reclaim neglected urban land and transform it into a meaningful public realm for the city.



ezgif.com-split.mp4

The site originally existed as a reserved open space that had gradually deteriorated into a dumping ground for construction debris and waste. Despite its strategic location near the Mula River and within a dense residential-commercial neighbourhood, the land had lost its identity, ecological value and social relevance over time. The presence of an existing temple on site further highlighted the emotional disconnect between the community and the neglected surroundings.



The project began with a fundamental question: how can forgotten urban land once again become meaningful public space?

The conceptual foundation of the project draws from the idea of “*Praan Pratishtha*” — the act of breathing life and spirit into something dormant. Rather than viewing the intervention merely as landscape development, the project approached the site as an act of urban regeneration — restoring ecological, cultural and social value simultaneously.



The narrative of the park is deeply inspired by the life and legacy of Late A.C.P. Ashok Kamte, one of the brave officers who sacrificed his life during the 26/11 attacks. Influenced by the book *To The Last Bullet* by Vinita Kamte and Vinita Deshmukh, the design transforms memory into spatial experience, allowing the landscape itself to become a medium of storytelling.

As visitors enter the park, the arrival plaza unfolds through vibrant floral landscapes, creating a sense of openness and welcome. The existing temple was consciously preserved within the design framework, acknowledging its emotional and cultural significance for the local community. Instead of erasing existing memory, the project sought to integrate it into a renewed public identity.



A linear colonnade structures the movement through the site, where each vertical element metaphorically reflects the stature, resilience and integrity associated with A.C.P. Ashok Kamte's legacy. The park gradually transitions into more interactive and collective zones — including an amphitheatre, public gathering spaces and playful installations such as a life-sized chess board and musical keyboard elements. These interventions encourage engagement across generations and transform the park into an active social landscape rather than a passive green space.

At its edge, the project reconnects people back to the riverfront — framing the river not as leftover infrastructure, but as a living ecological and urban asset. The journey through the park culminates at this softer landscape edge, symbolizing continuity, reflection and the enduring flow of collective memory.

The planning of the park was guided by the idea of holistic urban well-being. The zoning integrates physical, intellectual, social and environmental dimensions within a unified spatial framework. Recreational spaces coexist alongside contemplative zones, performance areas and ecological interventions, allowing the park to support multiple forms of occupation throughout the day.

Environmental responsiveness formed a critical component of the design approach. Dense native plantations inspired by the Miyawaki method were introduced to improve biodiversity and strengthen the riverfront microclimate. Native species were carefully selected not only for

ecological resilience, but also to respond to site-specific challenges such as odour mitigation from the nearby sewage treatment plant. Ashoka trees and layered vegetation systems were strategically integrated to improve environmental comfort across the site.

Material choices were equally rooted in contextual sensitivity. The project consciously adopted locally available materials such as Shahabad and Kota stone for paving and landscape elements, ensuring durability while reinforcing regional identity. The landscape also incorporates sustainable water management strategies, with treated water from the adjacent sewage treatment plant being reused for irrigation and maintenance purposes.

More than a park, Garvgaatha is envisioned as a civic catalyst — a space where memory, ecology and community intersect. The project reflects a broader belief that architecture and urban design are not merely tools for constructing cities, but instruments for building relationships between people.

In rapidly densifying urban environments where public spaces continue to shrink, projects such as Garvgaatha become increasingly significant. They demonstrate how neglected urban fragments can be transformed into inclusive, accessible and emotionally resonant environments that belong equally to all citizens.

Ultimately, the success of public space lies not in its physical form alone, but in the extent to which people begin to inhabit it, celebrate it and make it their own.

